

Epistemic Catastrophe

- Belief forming methods systematically mislead us and are therefore unreliable
- Stronger argument than Hume's Problem

Example in Natural Selection

R = our cognitive faculties are reliable

N = naturalism (not created by God)

E = our faculties are the product of natural selection

Question: what is $P(R | N \& E)$?

Argument: the probability of reliability given naturalism is true is very low. (Plantinga)

- Behaviors are derived from a collection of beliefs, desires
- Natural selection only cares for behaviors - not underlying causes
- Natural selection thus can produce unreliable belief forming methods as long as they produce the right behaviors
 - ex: belief that sun rises/sets rather than Earth rotating

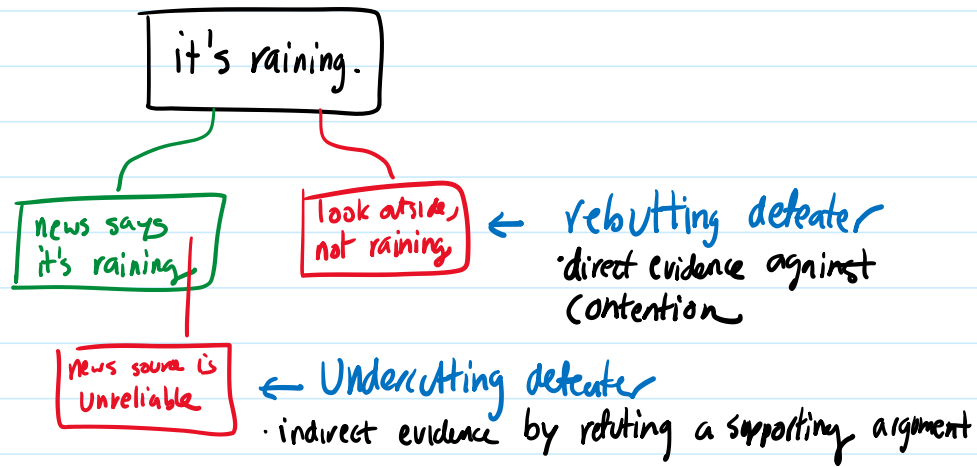
Additionally:

- We use cognitive faculties to determine the theory E.
 - ↳ E is an unreliable belief.
 - ↳ Cognitive instability: it is impossible to believe a theory that suggests that our belief forming methods are unreliable.

Defeaters

Definition: anything that weakens/refutes an argument

- 2 types: undercutting, rebutting



★ Cognitive instability $\Rightarrow$ an argument undercuts itself.

Formal definition: when it is impossible to rationally believe a theory

· a claim itself says it is likely to be false